Black in cultures and traditions

Black is a colour people long thought of as "obvious". Mourning, night, authority. Behind its reputation, though, are **more stories about fashion, commerce and faith than about the colour itself**. Let us visit a few places and read them carefully.

This chapter therefore shows **two levels**. First, how black is read in different **cultures**, and then how **traditional systems** look at it, using it as an image, not as instructions. What is verified history and what is later interpretation, I say in each part.

Black in different cultures

Egypt

In antiquity Egypt was called Kemet. The name appears from roughly the eleventh to twelfth dynasty and the hieroglyph km means black. Many scholars assume that the name refers to **the fertile black soil around the Nile**.

From a landscape where black is the colour of the earth from which grain grows. According to other interpretations the hieroglyph depicts a piece of smouldering coal.

Black here need not be an end. It can be **soil in which something begins**.

England

Prince Albert died in **1861** and Queen Victoria mourned so long and so visibly that it influenced the whole society. Victorian etiquette expected widows to mourn for two years and not to appear in society during the first year. Full mourning was followed by half mourning, when muted shades of lilac, grey and lavender could be worn.

From a time when colour became a rule that everyone had to follow, even those who did not feel that way.

Black here is **a social game with exact rules**. Grief, however, has no colour chart.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author’s written permission is not allowed.

Ghana

The Akan and Asante peoples in Ghana print adinkra cloth. Formerly it was worn by kings and spiritual leaders at funerals and on special occasions. It was printed on white, red, dark brown or black cotton. The patterns are stamped with carved calabash stamps with a dye from boiled bark and roots of the badie tree.

The oldest surviving cloth is from **1817** and since 1818 has been in the British Museum. Traditional production continues in Ntonso near Kumasi.

Black here carries **a word, a sign and a memory**. Not every sign is sad.

France

In **1926** American Vogue published a picture of Coco Chanel's short, simple black dress. The magazine called it "Chanel's Ford" because it was simple and accessible to women of all classes, and predicted that it would become "a sort of uniform for all women of taste".

Chanel said of black that she had "imposed" it and that it "wipes out everything else around". Black thus moved away from mourning and became a colour of elegance.

A colour can **change its meaning with one good cut**.

Black in traditional systems

Every tradition looks at black **a little differently**, but all take it seriously. It is an old symbolic language and an inspiration, not a healing manual.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author’s written permission is not allowed.

Traditional Chinese medicine

In the traditional five-element system black is linked with water, winter, the circuit of kidneys and bladder, and with fear. Water here does not mean just a glass on the table. It is also an image of depth, stillness and reserves. In winter not everything is dead just because nothing happens to be blooming.

The traditional kidney circuit is also linked with storing the essence jing. **Black clothing alone does not restore the kidneys or replenish jing.** For our colour story the image may remind you of long-term forces you handle.

How it relates to black. After a long period when you were constantly available, black may attract you as privacy. If you find relief in it, it can accompany a moment when you truly rest. Say you put down the phone and change into comfortable clothes. Colour can be part of the experience, **not a substitute for rest**.

And what if I asked you now?

"What do I no longer want to give out, and what do I need to keep?"

Fear, what I can't see I imagine

Darkness limits information. You do not know what is behind the door, and the imagination starts to work. Not every discomfort in a black room is, however, an "imbalance of water". Try to tell whether the colour bothers you, the lack of light, or a memory that the space awakens in you.

Winter should end with spring too

Stillness can restore strength. If it turns into a long withdrawal in which you are no longer well, there is no need to add more darkness. You can change the lighting, go outdoors in daylight or add to a black base a colour you want to see. **You do not have to choose one position forever.**

Traditional Chinese medicine uses the elements as an image. It is not a diagnosis and does not replace a doctor.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author's written permission is not allowed.

Ayurveda

Ayurveda is an old Indian teaching about health. It describes a person by three types of "energy", the so-called doshas. Vata (air, restlessness), pitta (fire, intensity) and kapha (earth and water, heaviness). Colours are not assigned to the doshas uniformly in the classical texts, so here you read **modern interpretations**, not an old table.

How it relates to black. In Ayurvedically inspired work we can ask about heaviness, lightness, warmth and cold. Black does not give the same experience in every material. A black woollen coat and black silk are quite different worlds.

Pitta

This describes a woman who is purposeful, quick and thorough, who flares up easily. Matte black and soft materials can feel cooling. Black on glossy metal and sharp contrast may, on the contrary, irritate.

- **Matt and soft**
  Calming, as a base.
- **Beware of shine**
  A sharp contrast can be an extra stimulus.

Vata

This describes a woman who is imaginative and quick, but restless and often cold. A warm black in wool and velvet can add warmth and a sense of firm boundaries. **It is best to notice how you really feel in it.**

- **Warm black and wool**
  Soft and earthy, without chill.
- **Evening and sleep**
  Soft textiles and warm light.

Kapha

This describes a woman who is calm, steady and patient, but who easily grows heavy. Large dark areas can deepen the heaviness, so give them **a light and lively companion**.

- **A light companion**
  Cream or wood as a counterweight.
- **Add movement**
  Red or yellow as an accent. A scarf, a tablecloth.

We will therefore not make black a universal ban or a remedy for a particular dosha. More interesting is whether a specific form brings you comfort, or weighs on you.

An online test will not reliably determine your dosha. If you are more interested, consult a qualified Ayurvedic practitioner. It is not treatment.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author's written permission is not allowed.

A Jungian view

Carl Gustav Jung, the Swiss psychiatrist, understood colours as symbols that have two layers. A personal one (what we have experienced with the colour) and one shared by all people (images that repeat across ages and cultures).

Jung did not describe black as a colour of its own. What I write next is my own reflection in the spirit of his thinking, not his statement. In alchemy nigredo, the blackening, means the first phase of transformation. In his works on alchemy Jung interpreted it as a symbolic image of meeting one's own shadow.

How it relates to black. In symbolic language you can read black as **the colour of the shadow and of what we do not yet know**. When you think about it, ask what in it is yours and what belongs to the expectations of others.

What you can take from it. Jung did not want colours turned into a dictionary. **We always ask what it means for you.** The same black can be a support for one woman and a weight for another. Jung's ideas about colours are a symbolic frame, not verified science.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author’s written permission is not allowed.

Feng shui

Feng shui is the Chinese art of arranging space so that it is good to live in. In feng shui interpretations black is commonly linked with water and can accompany the theme of depth, stillness and concentration. Schools differ in the assignments, so take it as one possibility.

Black is like ink

A little gives a space depth, a whole room turns it into a cave. Privacy is not the amount of black surfaces.

Simple tips

- **Start small**
  A black frame, shelf or lamp. A black frame does not behave like a black room.
- **Add more lights**
  Switch on several smaller points and add a lighter surface where you look most often.
- **Watch the surface**
  Matte and glossy black feel different. Gloss shows dust and fingerprints.
- **Give it wood**
  Wood, linen and wool add body.
- **Try it in daylight**
  See how it looks both in the morning and in the evening. Do you want to be in it?
- **Try textiles first**
  Before you repaint a wall, try a throw or a larger sample.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author’s written permission is not allowed.

What people say and what holds true

MYTH Black slims.

TRUTH A uniform dark whole without sharp breaks helps, but more than colour it is the cut and the material that decide. A badly fitting black rescues nothing.

MYTH Black is everywhere the colour of mourning.

TRUTH In many European countries yes, but in parts of Asia white is traditionally worn for mourning. The meaning is carried by custom, not the colour.

MYTH Black in feng shui brings bad luck.

TRUTH Black belongs to the element of water and is linked with depth and calm. A wholly black room without light, however, easily grows heavy. Details and good light are often enough.

What black goes well with

- **Wood and brown**
  A more bodily, warmer impression. Watch the amount of dark surfaces.
- **Cream**
  A gentler contrast than sharp white.
- **Green**
  Plants stand out strongly against a dark background.
- **Pink**
  Softness or fashionable boldness depending on the shade.
- **Gold**
  A festive detail. Too much shine can look ostentatious.
- **Red and white**
  Red is a very striking pair. White gives clear contrast, but with small patterns it can be distracting.

Elements

- **Water**
  Black is its natural stand-in. Make sure it does not outweigh.
- **Metal**
  White and light metal lighten it.
- **Wood**
  Green and wood enliven it.
- **Fire**
  Warm light and a red accent warm it up.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author's written permission is not allowed.

Feng shui room by room

Living room

What works. A black sofa, shelf or smaller wall can give a space a striking base. Next to **wood**, linen textiles and several smaller lights it feels cosy, not severe. A black picture frame or a thin metal shelf gives the room a line that holds the eye.

What to watch for. When all the large surfaces are dark (sofa, carpet, curtains), shapes and light are lost. The room can then feel more like a cinema than a place to sit and talk.

A simple tip. Switch on several smaller points instead of one ceiling light and add **a lighter surface** where you look most often. Ask whether you sit better here in the evening than in the morning.

Kitchen and bathroom

What works. Black cupboards, fittings and a thin handle can be beautiful and striking, especially next to a light worktop, wood or white tiles. A black tap is a lovely detail in a bathroom even when everything else is light.

What to watch for. On a glossy black surface you will see dust, grease and fingerprints more than you imagined. In hard water pale limescale quickly shows up. If you don't like wiping after every use, choose **a matte surface**.

A simple tip. Mind the lighting of the worktop and the material. Add **a difference of lightness** between the floor, wall and fittings so that the space does not merge into one dark surface.

Bedroom

What works. Black bedding, dark curtains or one dark wall behind the bed can create an intimate, enclosed impression. Some enjoy the feeling of a muted refuge, for another a dark bed recalls heaviness.

What to watch for. A black wall colour is not the same as blackout for sleep. Street light can penetrate a black room too. Dark bedding also quickly shows hairs and dust.

A simple tip. Notice the room in the daytime too. Do you want to be in it? Is it pleasant when you wake up? If not, add **one softer surface** (a beige blanket, linen or light wood) and see whether the impression changes.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author’s written permission is not allowed.

Children's room

What works. If a child or teenager wants black, ask what they like about it. Perhaps music, space, graphics, a poster or striking contrast. A small black element, say a chalkboard on the wall or a shelf, can be the part of the room that belongs only to them.

What to watch for. A black wall does not itself say that the child is unhappy. A conversation and overall behaviour will tell you more about their life than a tin of paint. Teenagers often try out with colour who they are.

A simple tip. Start with a smaller area, keep good lighting and **the possibility of change**. A black board or wardrobe can be repainted after a year when the child outgrows it.

Study

What works. A dark surrounding can limit some distracting reflections and help focus the gaze on a screen or paper. A black desk or shelf quietens visual noise when there are many small things around.

What to watch for. A very bright screen in the middle of a dark room may not be pleasant for the eyes. The contrast between a luminous monitor and a black wall behind it tires.

A simple tip. Add ambient lighting, say a lamp behind the monitor or on the desk. Black should not replace **a well-prepared workplace**.

Hall and entrance

What works. A black door, handle, coat rack or bench give the entrance firmness and match the coats and shoes that alternate here. A black mirror frame defines well the place where you check yourself one last time.

What to watch for. A narrow dark corridor without a window. There watch orientation and safe stairs so that dark surfaces do not merge with the floor.

A simple tip. Add a mirror, a lighter wall and a good lamp. An entrance should be a welcome, not a passage through a tunnel.

And try answering now

"Why do I want black at home? What should it bring me, privacy, depth, or courage?"

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author's written permission is not allowed.